

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1995-04-27

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í friend,

your email of 19 february 1995 addressed to the research department

2 which appear in a book you have recently read, and which seem from the context to
be citations from Shoghi effendi. These phrases are "b ahá'í

3 theocracy" and "humanity will emerge from that immature civilization in

4 which church and state are separate." you ask whether these references can

5 be authenticated and dated. we have been instructed to send you the fol-

6 lowing reply.

7 A reference to "b ahá'í theocracy" is to be found in a letter written on

8 behalf of the guardian to an individual bahá'í on 30 September 1949. This

9 reads as follows:

he thinks your question is well put: what the guardian was re-

ferring to was the theocratic systems, such as the catholic church

and the caliphate, which are not divinely given as systems, but man-

made, and yet, being partly derived from the teachings of christ and

10 200-3. pup , p. 174.200.13

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201 2a

202 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

28muḡammad are in a sense theocracies. The bahá'í theocracy, on the

contrary, is both divinely ordained as a system and, of course, based

203 on the teachings of the prophet himself.

The other passage does not comprise words of Shoghi effendi, although

204 its purport was approved by him. As you yourself have since discovered, it can be
found in The Bahá'í World, volume vi, on page 199, in a state-

205 ment entitled "concerning membership in Non-b ahá'í religious organiza-

206 tions," about which the guardian's secretary had written on his behalf on

11 december 1935: "The guardian has carefully read the copy of the state-

12 ment you had recently prepared concerning nonmembership in non-b ahá'í

13 religious organizations, and is pleased to realize that your comments and

explanations are in full conformity with his views on the subject."

14 The complete paragraph in which the words appear is as follows:

15 in the light of these words,

16 201-1 it seems fully evident that the way to

17 approach this instruction is in realizing the faith of bahá'u'lláh as an

18 ever-growing organism destined to become something new and greater than any of
the revealed religions of the past. whereas former faiths

19 inspired hearts and illumined souls, they eventuated in formal reli-gions with an
ecclesiastical organization, creeds, rituals and churches,

20 while the faith of bahá'u'lláh, likewise renewing man's spiritual life,

21 will gradually produce the institutions of an ordered society, fulfill-

22 ing not merely the function of the churches of the past but also the function of the
civil state. by this manifestation of the divine will

23 in a higher degree than in former ages, humanity will emerge from that immature
civilization in which church and state are separate and competitive institutions, and partake
of a true civilization in which

24 spiritual and social principles are at last reconciled as two aspects of

25 one and the same T ruth.

26 201-1. reference to a letter of 15 june 1935 from Shoghi effendi, published in the

27 united States Bahá'í News, no. 95, october 1935, p. 2, and in Messages to America:

28 Selected Letters and Cablegrams Addressed to the Bahá'ís of North America,
1932-1946

29 (wilmette: bahá'í publishing committee, 1947), pp. 4-5. The referenced text can

also be found in Tdh, no. 16.201.3

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201 4a

29you also ask how these statements could be reconciled with Shoghi

203 effendi's comment on page 149 of Bahá'í Administration, which appears to
204 anticipate "a future that is sure to witness the formal and complete separa-
205 tion of church and State," and with the following words in his letter of 21
206 march 1932 addressed to the bahá'ís of the united States and canada:

Theirs is not the purpose, while endeavoring to conduct and per-

fect the administrative affairs of their faith, to violate, under any

207 circumstances, the provisions of their country's constitution, much less to allow the
machinery of their administration to supersede the

208 government of their respective countries.

209 201-2

A careful reading of the letter dated 6 december 1928 in which the

guardian's comment about the separation of church and State occurs

210 would suggest that, rather than enunciating a general principle, Shoghi
211 effendi is simply reviewing "the quickening forces of internal reform" that
212 had "recently transpired throughout the Near and middle east," and enu-
213 merating a number of factors that impinge on the development of the faith

in those parts of the world.201-3

As for the statement made by Shoghi effendi in his letter of 21 march

214 1932, the well-established principles of the faith concerning the relationship
215 of the bahá'í institutions to those of the country in which the bahá'ís reside
216 make it unthinkable that they would ever purpose to violate a country's
217 constitution or so to meddle in its political machinery as to attempt to take over the
powers of government. This is an integral element of the bahá'í
218 principle of abstention from involvement in politics. however, this does
219 not by any means imply that the country itself may not, by constitutional means,
decide to adopt bahá'í laws and practices and modify its constitu-
220 tion or method of government accordingly. The relationship between the
221 principle of abstention from involvement in politics and the emergence of
222 the bahá'í State is commented on later in this letter. in the meantime we can

223 quote the following extracts from letters written on behalf of the guardian
224 in response to queries from individual believers, which indicate that the relationship
is an evolving one:

225 201-2. wob, p. 66.

226 201-3. bA, p. 147 .201.5

201 5a

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202 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

Oregarding the question raised in your letter, Shoghi effendi be-

lieves that for the present the movement, whether in the east or

the west, should be dissociated entirely from politics. This was the

203 explicit injunction of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá. . . . eventually, however, as you

have rightly conceived it, the movement will, as soon as it is fully

204 developed and recognized, embrace both religious and political issues.

205 in fact bahá’u’lláh clearly states that affairs of state as well as religious

questions are to be referred to the houses of justice into which the

206 Assemblies of the b ahá’ís will eventually evolve.

(0 November 190)

The b ahá’ís will be called upon to assume the reins of government

207 when they will come to constitute the majority of the population in a given country,
and even then their participation in political affairs is

208 bound to be limited in scope unless they obtain a similar majority in some other
countries as well.

(19 November 199)

The bahá’ís must remain non-partisan in all political affairs. in the

distant future, however, when the majority of a country have become

209 bahá’ís then it will lead to the establishment of a b ahá’í State.

(19 April 191)

210 A proper understanding of all the above passages, and of their implica-

211 tions, requires an acceptance of two fundamental principles for the exegesis of bahá'í
212 Texts.

The first, which derives from the covenant, is the principle that the

212 writings of 'Abdu'l-b ahá and the guardian are thoroughly imbued with the
213 spirit of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh and intimately linked with the Teach-
214 ings of bahá'u'lláh himself. This principle is clearly expounded in two
215 paragraphs from a letter written on behalf of the guardian to an individual
216 believer on 19 m arch 1946:

whatever the master has said is based on the teachings of

bahá'u'lláh. he was the perfect interpreter, had lived with him all

217 his life; therefore what he says has the same standing, even if a text

of bahá'u'lláh is not available. . . .201.7a

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202 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

1we must take the teachings as a great, balanced whole, not seek

out and oppose to each other two strong statements that have dif-

ferent meanings; somewhere in between, there are links uniting the

two. That is what makes our faith so flexible and well balanced. for

203 instance there are calamities for testing and for punishment—there are also accidents,
plain cause and effect!

bahá'u'lláh has given us a revelation designed to raise mankind to

204 heights never before attained. it is little wonder that the minds of individual

205 believers, no matter how perceptive, have difficulty in comprehending its

206 range. it is the words of 'Abdu'l-b ahá and the guardian which elucidate this

207 vast revelation and make clear the manner in which different statements

208 relate to one another and what is implied by the revealed word. without

209 the bright light of the covenant, this faith, like all those before it, would
210 be torn to pieces by the conflicting opinions of scholars applying limited
211 human reasoning to divinely revealed truths.

The second fundamental principle which enables us to understand the

212 pattern towards which bahá'u'lláh wishes human society to evolve is the
213 principle of organic growth which requires that detailed developments, and the
understanding of detailed developments, become available only with the passage of time
and with the help of the guidance given by that central

214 Authority in the cause to whom all must turn. in this regard one can use
215 the simile of a tree. if a farmer plants a tree, he cannot state at that moment
216 what its exact height will be, the number of its branches or the exact time
217 of its blossoming. he can, however, give a general impression of its size and
218 pattern of growth and can state with confidence which fruit it will bear.

219 The same is true of the evolution of the world order of bahá'u'lláh. for
220 example, we find the following illuminating explanation in a letter written
221 by Shoghi Effendi to the bahá'ís in America on 23 February 1924:

And as we make an effort to demonstrate that love to the world

222 may we also clear our minds of any lingering trace of unhappy mis-understandings
that might obscure our clear conception of the exact

223 purpose and methods of this new world order, so challenging and complex, yet so
consummate and wise. we are called upon by our

beloved master in his will and Testament not only to adopt it unre-

224 servedly, but to unveil its merit to all the world. To attempt to estimate 201.9b

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202 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

203 2 its full value, and grasp its exact significance after so short a time since

its inception would be premature and presumptuous on our part. we

must trust to time, and the guidance of god's universal house of

204 justice, to obtain a clearer and fuller understanding of its provisions

and implications. but one word of warning must be uttered in this

connection. let us be on our guard lest we measure too strictly the

divine plan with the standard of men. i am not prepared to state that

205 it agrees in principle or in method with the prevailing notions now uppermost in
men's minds, nor that it should conform with those imperfect, precarious, and expedient
measures feverishly resorted to

by agitated humanity. Are we to doubt that the ways of god are not

206 necessarily the ways of man? is not faith but another word for implicit

207 obedience, wholehearted allegiance, uncompromising adherence to that which we
believe is the revealed and express will of god, however

208 perplexing it might first appear, however at variance with the shadowy

209 views, the impotent doctrines, the crude theories, the idle imaginings, the fashionable
conceptions of a transient and troublous age? if we are

210 to falter or hesitate, if our love for him should fail to direct us and

211 keep us within his path, if we desert divine and emphatic principles,

212 what hope can we any more cherish for healing the ills and sicknesses of this world?

213 function it is to lay more definitely the broad lines that must guide the future
activities and administration of the movement, it is clearly our

214 duty to strive to obtain as clear a view as possible of the manner in which to conduct
the affairs of the cause, and then arise with single-

215 mindedness and determination to adopt and maintain it in all our activities and
labors.

216 201-4

At this time we have the benefit of many subsequent interpretations

217 by Shoghi effendi and also the initial guidance of the universal house

218 of justice, which will continue to elucidate aspects of this mighty system

219 as it unfolds. in striving to attain a "clearer and fuller understanding" of

220 the world order of bahá'u'lláh, we need to contemplate the operation of

221 the bahá'í principles of governance and social responsibility as they persist

222 201-4. bA, p. 62.201.11b

201 12

202 1993-1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

203 through changing sets of conditions, from the present time when the bahá'í

community constitutes a small number of people living in a variety of

204 overwhelmingly non-bahá'í societies, to the far different situation in future
205 centuries when the bahá'ís are becoming, and eventually have become, the
206 vast majority of the people.

The Administrative order is certainly the nucleus and pattern of the

207 world order of bahá'u'lláh, but it is in embryonic form, and must undergo
208 major evolutionary developments in the course of time. certain passages
209 in the writings on this subject establish matters of principle, certain ones
210 describe the ultimate goal of the most great peace, and certain of them
211 relate to stages of development on the way to the attainment of that goal. for
example, in this familiar passage in his will and Testament, 'Abdu'l-
212 bahá states:

This house of justice enacteth the laws and the government enforceth

213 them. The legislative body must reinforce the executive, the executive must aid and
assist the legislative body so that through the close union

and harmony of these two forces, the foundation of fairness and jus-

214 tice may become firm and strong, that all the regions of the world may become even
as paradisa itself.

215 201-5

216 in response to a question about the "government" in the above passage,
217 Shoghi effendi's secretary wrote on his behalf, on 18 April 1941, the follow-
218 ing clarification:

by "government" . . . is meant the executive body which will enforce

219 the laws when the bahá'í faith has reached the point when it is recog-

nized and accepted entirely by any particular nation.201-6

220 The same relationship between legislature and executive is expressed in
221 the well-known passage in "The unfoldment of world civilization," show-
222 ing how one principle is applied over successive periods.

223 201-5. w T, pp. 14-15.

224 201-6. lg, no. 1604.201.13

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201 14a

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202 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

**A world executive, backed by an international force, will carry
out the decisions arrived at, and apply the laws enacted by, this
world legislature, and will safeguard the organic unity of the whole
commonwealth.201-7**

203 in relation to other international institutions, the guardian has given the
204 following guidance:

205 Touching the point raised in the Secretary's letter regarding the nature
and scope of the universal court of Arbitration, this and other simi-

lar matters will have to be explained and elucidated by the universal

206 house of justice, to which, according to the master's explicit instruc-
tions, all important fundamental questions must be referred.201-8

207 in his letter to the National Spiritual Assembly of the bahá'ís of the
united States and canada written on 27 february 1929, Shoghi effendi

208 stated:

209 Not only will the present-day Spiritual Assemblies be styled differ-ently in future,
but they will be enabled also to add to their present functions those powers, duties, and
prerogatives necessitated by the

210 recognition of the faith of bahá'u'lláh, not merely as one of the rec-

211 ognized religious systems of the world, but as the State religion of an

independent and Sovereign power. And as the bahá'í faith permeates

the masses of the peoples of east and west, and its truth is embraced

by the majority of the peoples of a number of the Sovereign States of

its power, and exercise as the supreme organ of the bahá'í common-

212 wealth all the rights, the duties and responsibilities incumbent upon the world's
future superstate.

213 201-9

complementing these words are the guardian's repeated and force-

214 ful requirement that bahá'ís strictly abstain from involvement in politics.

215 This requirement has far-reaching implications for the method by which

216 201-7 . wob, p. 203.

217 201-8. bA, p. 47 .201-9. wob, pp. 6–7 .201.15a

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202 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

203 5bahá'u'lláh's Administrative order will evolve into his world order. we

204 can consider, for example, the well-known passage in his letter of 21 march

205 1932 to the b ahá'ís in the u nited States and canada:

let them refrain from associating themselves, whether by word or

206 by deed, with the political pursuits of their respective nations, with

the policies of their governments and the schemes and programs of

207 parties and factions. . . . let them affirm their unyielding determina-

208 tion to stand, firmly and unreservedly, for the way of bahá'u'lláh, to

avoid the entanglements and bickerings inseparable from the pursuits

209 of the politician, and to become worthy agencies of that divine polity

210 which incarnates g od's immutable p urpose for all men. . . .

. . . let them beware lest, in their eagerness to further the aims of

their beloved cause, they should be led unwittingly to bargain with

211 their faith, to compromise with their essential principles, or to sacri-

212 fice, in return for any material advantage which their institutions may

derive, the integrity of their spiritual ideals.201-10

213 As one studies these words, one begins to understand the processes at work in the gradual unfoldment and establishment of the b ahá'í System.

clearly the establishment of the kingdom of god on earth is a “po-

214 litical” enterprise, and the Teachings of the faith are filled with “political”
 215 principles—using the word in the sense of the science of government and of the
 organization of human society. At the same time the bahá’í world
 216 community repeatedly and emphatically denies being a “political” organiza-tion, and
 bahá’ís are required, on pain of deprivation of their administrative
 217 rights, to refrain from becoming involved in “political” matters and from taking sides
 in “political” disputes. in other words, the bahá’ís are following
 218 a completely different path from that usually followed by those who wish to reform
 society. They eschew political methods towards the achievement of their aims, and
 concentrate on revitalizing the hearts, minds and behavior
 219 of people and on presenting a working model as evidence of the reality and
 220 practicality of the way of life they propound.

The bahá’í Administrative order is the “nucleus and pattern”

221 201-11 of the
 222 divinely intended future political system of the world, and undoubtedly
 223 201-10. wob, pp. 64–65.
 224 201-11. cf , p. 5.201.18a
 201 18b
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 201 20
 202 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 203 6non-b ahá’í governments will benefit from learning how this system works
 204 and from adopting its procedures and principles in overcoming the prob-
 205 lems they face. Nevertheless, this Administration is primarily the framework
 206 and structure designed to be a channel for the flow of the spirit of the cause
 207 and for the application of its Teachings. As the g uardian wrote:
 208 it is surely for those to whose hands so priceless a heritage has been
 209 committed to prayerfully watch lest the tool should supersede the faith itself, lest
 undue concern for the minute details arising from
 210 the administration of the cause obscure the vision of its promoters,
 211 lest partiality, ambition, and worldliness tend in the course of time to becloud the
 radiance, stain the purity, and impair the effectiveness of the f aith of b ahá’u’lláh.
 212 201-12

213 The gradual process of the evolution of the bahá'í Administrative order
214 into the world order of bahá'u'lláh has been described by Shoghi effendi
215 in many of his writings, as in the following excerpt from his letter of 30 April 1953 to
the All-America i ntercontinental Teaching conference:

216 This present crusade, on the threshold of which we now stand,
217 will, moreover, by virtue of the dynamic forces it will release and its wide
repercussions over the entire surface of the globe, contribute effectually to the acceleration of
yet another process of tremendous significance which will carry the steadily evolving faith of
bahá'u'lláh

218 through its present stages of obscurity, of repression, of emancipation and of
recognition—stages one or another of which bahá'í national

communities in various parts of the world now find themselves—to

219 the stage of establishment, the stage at which the faith of bahá'u'lláh
220 will be recognized by the civil authorities as the State religion, similar
221 to that which christianity entered in the years following the death of

the emperor constantine, a stage which must later be followed by

222 the emergence of the bahá'í state itself, functioning, in all religious

and civil matters, in strict accordance with the laws and ordinances

of the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the most holy, the mother-book of the bahá'í

223 revelation, a stage which, in the fullness of time, will culminate in the

224 201-12. wob, p. 10.201.20a

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201 21a

202 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

7establishment of the world bahá'í commonwealth, functioning in

203 the plenitude of its powers, and which will signalize the long-awaited

advent of the christ-promised kingdom of god on earth—the king-

dom of bahá'u'lláh—mirroring however faintly upon this humble

handful of dust the glories of the Abhá kingdom.201-13

in answer to those who raise objections to this vision of a worldwide

204 commonwealth inspired by a divine revelation, fearing for the freedom of

205 minority groups or of the individual under such a system, we can explain
 206 the bahá'í principle of upholding the rights of minorities and fostering their
 207 interests. we can also point to the fact that no person is ever compelled to
 208 accept the faith of bahá'u'lláh and moreover, unlike the situation in certain
 209 other religions, each person has complete freedom to withdraw from the faith if he
 decides that he no longer believes in its founder or accepts his
 210 Teachings. in light of these facts alone it is evident that the growth of the
 211 bahá'í communities to the size where a non-b ahá'í state would adopt the
 212 faith as the State religion, let alone to the point at which the State would
 213 accept the law of god as its own law and the National house of justice as
 214 its legislature, must be a supremely voluntary and democratic process.
 215 National Spiritual Assembly of the b ahá'ís of the u nited States:

it is not our purpose to impose bahá'í teachings upon others by per-

216 suading the powers that be to enact laws enforcing bahá'í principles,
 217 nor to join movements which have such legislation as their aim. The guidance that
 bahá'í institutions offer to mankind does not comprise
 218 a series of specific answers to current problems, but rather the illu-

mination of an entirely new way of life. without this way of life the

219 problems are insoluble; with it they will either not arise or, if they
 220 arise, can be resolved.

221 T wo quotations from the writings of the guardian bear particularly on
 222 these principles of the rights and prerogatives of minorities and of individu-
 223 als. in The Advent of Divine Justice is a passage which is of fundamental
 224 significance for b ahá'í constitutional law:

225 201-13. mbw , p. 155.201.22

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202 m eS Sa g e S f ro m Th e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

203 8unlike the nations and peoples of the earth, be they of the east or

204 of the west, democratic or authoritarian, communist or capitalist,

205 whether belonging to the old world or the New, who either ignore,
206 trample upon, or extirpate, the racial, religious, or political minorities
207 within the sphere of their jurisdiction, every organized community enlisted under the
banner of bahá'u'lláh should feel it to be its first
208 and inescapable obligation to nurture, encourage, and safeguard every minority
belonging to any faith, race, class, or nation within it.

209 201-14

210 As for the protection of the rights of individuals, there is the follow-
211 ing translation of a forceful passage which appears in a letter from Shoghi
212 effendi to the bahá'ís of iran, written in july 1925, in relation to a situation
213 involving a covenant-breaker:

... the mere fact of disaffection, estrangement, or recantation of

belief, can in no wise detract from, or otherwise impinge upon, the

214 legitimate civil rights of individuals in a free society, be it to the most insignificant
degree. were the friends to follow other than this course,

it would be tantamount to a reversion on their part, in this century

215 of radiance and light, to the ways and standards of a former age: they
216 would reignite in men's breasts the fire of bigotry and blind fanati-cism, cut
themselves off from the glorious bestowals of this promised

day of god, and impede the full flow of divine assistance in this

217 wondrous age.

218 All bahá'ís, and especially those who make a profound study of the cause,
219 need to grasp the differences between the bahá'í concepts of governance and
220 those of the past, and to abstain from measuring bahá'í institutions and

methods against the faulty man-made institutions and methods hitherto

221 current in the world. The guardian graphically stressed these differences in
222 his letter of 8 february 1934, known as "The dispensation of bahá'u'lláh":

The bahá'í commonwealth of the future, of which this vast Ad-

223 ministrative order is the sole framework, is, both in theory and prac-
224 tice, not only unique in the entire history of political institutions,

225 201-14. Adj, ¶52.201.24a

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202 1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

203 9but can find no parallel in the annals of any of the world's recognized

religious systems. No form of democratic government; no system of

autocracy or of dictatorship, whether monarchical or republican; no

204 intermediary scheme of a purely aristocratic order; nor even any of the recognized
types of theocracy, whether it be the hebrew com-

monwealth, or the various christian ecclesiastical organizations, or

the imamate or the caliphate in islam—none of these can be identi-

fied or be said to conform with the Administrative order which the

205 master-hand of its perfect Architect has fashioned.

206 201-15

Among the many complementary Teachings in the faith which resolve

207 the dilemmas of past societies are those of the unity of mankind on the

208 one hand, and loyalty to the covenant on the other. As already mentioned,

209 no one in this dispensation is compelled to be a bahá'í, and the division

210 of humankind into the "clean" and the "unclean," the "faithful" and the

211 "infidels," is abolished. At the same time, anyone who does choose to be

212 a bahá'í accepts the covenant of bahá'u'lláh and, while free expression of

213 opinion within the bahá'í community is encouraged, this cannot ever be

214 permitted to degenerate to the level of undermining the covenant, for this

215 would vitiate the very purpose of the revelation itself.

216 bahá'í Administrative order unfolds, will be to ensure that it evolves in

217 consonance with the spirit of the bahá'í revelation. while many beneficial

218 aspects of human society at large can be safely incorporated into bahá'í

219 Administration, the house of justice will guard against the corrupting influ-

220 ence of those non-bahá'í political and social concepts and practices which

221 are not in harmony with the divine standard.
222 The house of justice appreciates your concern about such a fundamental
223 issue, and asks us to assure you of its prayers in the holy Shrines for the
224 confirmation of your services to the cause of God.
225 with loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

226 201-15. wob, p. 152.201.27

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202 Messages from The Universal House of Justice

0202

Ruling of Supreme Court in India Citing the Bahá'í

Teachings as a Guideline for Resolving Disputes

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]